a fraction of the total features provided in professional products like Microsoft Office, while a free office suite like OpenOffice.org made more sense and thus, they shifted."

Those at Sheela Foam, that's been using Red Hat Enterprise Linux since April 2009, couldn't agree more. "We invested only about Rs 8 lakhs and expect to incur a saving of Rs 50 lakhs spread over three years, because of migrating from proprietary software," says Mankotia.

A small NGO like IT For Change, running about 21 laptops and desktops on Ubuntu, and using OpenOffice.org Writer and Calc, admits to obvious cost benefits by switching to FOSS for generic applications. "FOSS has helped us save on license costs, service costs, and upgrade costs. We have saved on 21 Windows and MS Office licences which adds up to approximately Rs 3 lakhs," says Kasinathan. Alongside, De's study shows that the IT@schools project that replaced the Windows OS on 50,000 desktop computers in 2,800 schools across the state with a FOSS OS, saved around Rs 490 million, while an e-commerce arm of a Mumbai-based retail chain saved Rs 3 million by replacing MS Office with OpenOffice.org.

However, a lot of doubts have been raised about data migration and integration when it comes to open source applications, and regarding open source as an operating system. "We initially thought that migration would be difficult. However, we experienced that it was quite simple. We did not require much training and there were no issues of integration, scalability, etc," says Mankotia, nullifying any doubts about transitional hiccups.

FOSS replacement on servers either as operating systems hosting application products, or as enterprise class products, too, has helped organisations enter the 'save mode'. "We used Red Hat advanced server 4.0 and enjoyed immense savings on hardware costs, since a RISC server cost us 40 per cent more than an x86 server," says Choudhury. New India Assurance that migrated about 1500 servers to open source and also a large part of its desktops to Linux, saved about 35 to 40 per cent on IT expenditure, which amounted to Rs 800 million, reveals De's study. Further, Sheela Foam that shifted about three servers to open source said that its maintenance costs dropped to one-sixth after migrating to a FOSS-based system.

A Computer Security Institute/FBI report in 2006 stated that the loss from virus-related problems for about 300 firms in the US was close to $ 50 million. Indian firms too have reported massive losses owing to attacks from viruses and worms. One estimate places the recovery time to be, at an average, 29 hours from each serious virus attack. In most businesses where time is money, this amounts to huge losses. Using a FOSS operating system on the desktop very often requires no anti-virus software. "One of the servers is used for the security firewall, proxy, etc. We have not purchased any anti-virus software, so it is a 100 per cent saving on the security front because of using FOSS," testifies Singh. Other perks availed by organisations going in for FOSS include a 30 per cent cut in energy bills for Sheela Foam.

Further, FOSS has been crucial to organisations pressing the innovation keys to improve the way they function. "FOSS has immense innovation potential. It provides a platform for the creative development of software and aggregation of applications. It enables organisations and individuals to experiment with, tinker with and play around with different combinations of hardware, software and applications. This has a potential to create immense benefits for the firm," says De.

At IIC, FOSS products enable students to experiment with and hence learn about software. "OSS and innovation go hand in hand. Students choose to work on open source projects, because they get enough freedom to explore, which is a crucial component of any learning process. Now we are at a stage where we have enough projects developed over training periods. These can be used for the academic requirements of any institution. They include developments like algorithms for the Gnome rice project (for sequence mapping and motif identification), network monitoring, alumni database systems, academic portal frameworks, etc, which we release as an open source software resource toolkit," says Singh.

Kasinathan says: "FOSS has helped foster innovation—perhaps not as much for our organisational performance as much as for the projects we undertake. We support and encourage other organisations to innovate in other areas such as education. For instance, we are collaborating with a partner organisation to create a customised distribution of Debian, including educational packages and local language support, which will be used in government schools for computer education."

"If we have to innovate or test anything now, we can replicate our data in any machine, as our OS is not machine-dependent, which in turn has helped us innovate more. We have not only saved costs, our boundaries too have been eliminated to a great extent," adds Mankotia. According to De's study, others like New India Assurance and the IT@Schools project too have innovated successfully using FOSS.

In a nutshell

Altogether, FOSS has been instrumental in helping organisations achieve superior benchmarks without huge costs. People have begun to appreciate the benefits of using FOSS to create, connect and share. And once begun, this trend will only grow. END

By: Vanisha Joseph

The author loves to experiment and writing for LINUX For You is her latest experiment. So, beware! Just a minute, she also happens to be a journalist during the day.